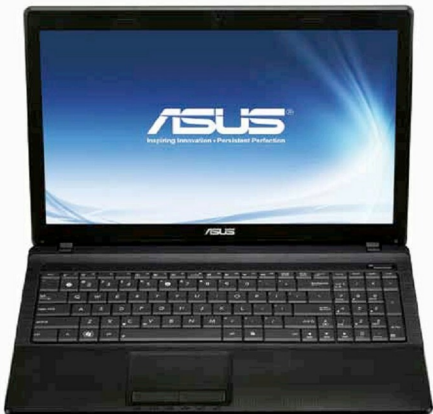


Budget Laptops

Expensive things are not always the best. Amidst a plethora of brands and specification points, doing some good research and planning can easily get you a superb value-for-money laptop



ASUS X54C-SX261D

PRIY PANDIT

No matter how much attention the uber-cool tablet PCs grab these days, the utility of laptops cannot be ignored. From preparing those tedious spreadsheets to multi-tasking between an online troubleshooting session and hanging on with your distant cousin via a chat client, the comfort of a real keyboard is still unmatched. Recent changes in computing hardware have churned

out some new breed of devices which have brought collateral alterations to laptops too.

With a vague idea in your mind, you enter the neighbourhood consumer electronics store to buy a budget laptop. A few steps inside the store, you are surrounded by umpteen choices of laptops that come in a variety of price-points, screen sizes, specifications and battery lives. To add to the daunting task of making the right choice, the nettlesome executives in the store will further heighten the confusion

by throwing in inexplicable tech jargon.

So if you have a below-Rs 25,000 budget for your dream laptop, make sure you keep a tab on the following checkpoints to get the best deal.

Screen size

The traditional sub-25cm (sub-10-inch) screen netbooks are still pretty hot in the market. If you travel a lot, look for an ultra-light model in the 26cm (10.1-inch) or 29cm (11.6-inch) segment. However, if you want the utmost in terms of mobility, battery life and performance, opt for a screen size between 33 cm and 36 cm (13 and 14 inches).

Going beyond, a screen size of 38 cm (15 inches) or bigger is good only if you rarely plan to carry your laptop. A bigger screen will better address your entertainment needs but make sure it sports a resolution of at least 1366x768 pixels. Otherwise, it will be a waste of money and space.

Processor

A quad-core Intel Core i7 and a first-generation Atom processor show up noticeable differences even if you are browsing the Internet. The processor acts as the engine of your laptop. So ensure your laptop is powered by a processor according to your computing needs.

Tasks such as encoding an HD DVD to your smartphone-friendly format or editing your farewell party's footage in a video editing tool demand a high processing power. In this case, a faster processor such as Intel Core i3 or Intel Core 2 Duo can save a lot of time.

For designing PowerPoint presentations and Excel spreadsheets and